might even, for example, decide to opt for Pakistan, which would completely disprove Nehru's claim of Abdullah being the embodiment of the Kashmiri people's desire to remain in India. He was permitted an extraordinary degree of latitude in the process of establishing machinery for the devising of a constitution for the Jammu and Kashmir Constituent Assembly.

It would not be far from the truth to argue that from the Indian point of view, late October 1947 onwards, Abdullah was what is sometimes called a loose cannon. This view was reinforced when from 5 March 1948, Mahajan disappeared and Abdullah became the undisputed leader, with the pompous title of the Prime Minister of a 'popular' interim government, amidst considerable publicity. The departure of Mahajan marked the end of the final, albeit tenuous, link between the new regime and a form of government which had some roots in the previous constitutional arrangement. In a very real sense, Abdullah was now an absolute ruler and it was clearly in the interest of the Government of India that some fresh constitutional checks be devised. These would have to involve not only the structure of the internal government of the state but also the state's formal relationship with the Indian Union. The need for these checks arose because of Abdullah's written vision for Kashmir, which was first published in 1944.

In his 1944 *Naya*, or New, Kashmir proposals, which were drafted by Oxford-educated communist ideologue Baba Pyare Lal Bedi (father of Bollywood actor Kabir Bedi), Sheikh Abdullah articulated his vision for the conversion of Jammu and Kashmir into an independent state, which he liked to describe as a South Asian Switzerland. This state could perhaps exist in alliance with the newly independent India but would not be an integral part of it. This remained a dominant theme in his discourses right up to his death in 1982. Abdullah's Kashmir would be secular but it would also be dominated by a Muslim majority and would thus acquire a strong Islamic sheen. Abdullah's acclaimed secularism could well have been a misunderstood version of what can only be described as a variety of Kashmiri nationalism. He argued, on a number of occasions, that just as